Pointing Is Shared Reference, Not a Language Product

Declarative pointing is concurrently and longitudinally associated with language; commercial baby-sign packages are a different, inconclusive claim.

GRADE: MODERATE-REFERENCE; LOW-PRODUCT | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: LANGUAGE, SOCIAL | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Pointing can coordinate two minds around one referent. Colonnesi, Stams, Koster & Noom (2010) found pointing associated with language concurrently (r = .52) and longitudinally (r = .35) across 25 studies (734 children), for declarative/general pointing, not imperative pointing. Commercial baby-sign packages for typically developing hearing infants are a different claim: Fitzpatrick et al. (2014) found inconclusive language advantages and no evidence of harm.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Colonnesi et al. (2010), Developmental Review, is an observational meta-analysis. Shared attention, motor, and learning capacities can drive both gesture and speech. Longitudinal r = .35 is prediction, not an RCT of "more pointing." Fitzpatrick, Thibert, Grandpierre & Johnston (2014) reviewed gestural-communication programs in typically developing hearing infants under 36 months: language benefits inconclusive; one randomized study found no advantage on standardized measures. Joint attention (Mundy & Newell) is not re-extracted here.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Concurrent association is large by social-development standards; longitudinal association is moderate. Neither is a treatment effect for a marketed curriculum.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (developmental communicative milestone, not an observational population phenotype association).

Age, pointing motive, and language modality moderate the Colonnesi estimates. SES and country were examined as moderators; they do not license a parental purity test. Baby-sign trials are small and mixed. Genetically informed attenuation: n/a.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean a quiet pointer is delayed. Does not mean baby-sign products are required, harmful, or equivalent to naturally emerging gesture. Does not mean Hart & Risley.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Treat pointing and showing as ordinary shared reference. Purchasing a sign package to accelerate typical speech is not justified here.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Colonnesi, Stams, Koster & Noom (2010), Developmental Review (DOI 10.1016/j.dr.2010.10.001)
- Fitzpatrick, Thibert, Grandpierre & Johnston (2014), First Language (DOI 10.1177/0142723714562864)